COUNTRY REPORTS: CAMEROON

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Status report

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The national artificial intelligence strategy was presented in July 2025 as a clear framework for Cameroon's digital future; a year later, at the cabinet meeting of 30 July 2026, the Prime Minister instructed that it be completed, an implementation roadmap having been tabled at the same session. Ten priority areas for artificial intelligence in scientific research were set out at the same meeting, among them a sovereign scientific database, a national high-performance computing centre, AI modules in training curricula, mobilisation of diaspora expertise, and adaptation of the legal framework for governance, sovereignty and data protection. None is funded or established.

Behind the AI work, the machinery is thinner than the volume of announcement suggests. The GovTech and digital transformation strategy is planned or in draft rather than adopted, there is no dedicated government entity for data governance and no data governance strategy or policy, and there is no open source software policy or action plan for the public sector, nor any entity deciding on open source adoption (2025). The GovTech entity that does exist has no coordination body above it and no entity monitoring digital spending across government.

Delivery documents are sectoral or local rather than whole-of-government: an update of the Digital Master Plan for the country's 394 decentralised local authorities, announced in July 2025, and a completed three-year government study of the country's data centres, presented in May 2025 with a call for incentive-based policies to support data-centre development.

The stated posture is a controlled acceleration of artificial intelligence development, with the sovereignty case put in market terms — that otherwise other countries benefit from the market for data produced in Cameroon (July 2026). It is being pursued from a weak base: Cameroon scores 42.9 out of 100 for overall governance, 39th of 54 African states and down 2.1 points over 2014-2023 while the continental average rose, and scores below the African average on 71 of the index's 96 indicators (2023).

Legislation and regulation

Cameroon enacted two of the most consequential statutes in its digital estate on the same day, 23 December 2024: Law No. 2024/017 on the protection of personal data, and a civil registration reform that gives digital civil status certificates the same legal value as paper ones and establishes a unique personal identification number. The deadline for organisations to comply with the data protection law passed on 23 June 2026.

What sits beside them is a set of holes that a year of activity has not closed. There is no comprehensive standalone regulation of digital identity: the 2025 decree governs issuance of the identity card and nothing wider, and a World Bank diagnostic found the legal framework for digital identity inadequate. There is no right-to-information law in force, with a draft in consultation as at 2025. And the posts minister counted the need for a legal framework that settles responsibilities, data protection and public order among the challenges of artificial intelligence (July 2026).

A draft e-government law on access to public information received technical validation at a government workshop at Ebolowa in November 2025 and was ready for ministerial finalisation in January 2026; it would make public information accessible by default, require proactive publication and place interoperability under GovTech Cameroun. Validation is not enactment, and no adopting instrument is published.

The binding regime is therefore mostly older law. Cybercrime rests on Law 2010/012 of 2010, which civil society organisations argued in June 2026 contains provisions that limit freedom of expression. The state's own records remain anchored in paper, the Criminal Procedure Code of 2005 requiring judicial police officers to write up investigations in procès-verbaux. Where new instruments have been made, they have been fiscal ones: Decree No. 2022/8001 established the legal basis for electronic payment of taxes, customs duties and other state revenue, and the IMEI-based collection of import duty on mobile devices rests on Article 6 of the 2023 Finance Law, which the government presents as enforcement of an existing duty rather than a new tax.

Data protection

The deadline for organisations to comply with Cameroon's personal data protection law passed on 23 June 2026, on the finance ministry's budget directorate's account, with no supervisor in place to apply it: Law No. 2024/017 was enacted on 23 December 2024, and the protection authority it provides for had not been established as at 2025, with nothing published on data protection complaints or regulatory performance.

The rights environment around it has deteriorated sharply. Personal Liberties fell 30.3 points over 2014-2023 to 26.5 out of 100, 39th of 54 and the country's fifth most deteriorated governance indicator of 96. Internet access was restricted on 23 October 2025, in the presidential election period, a measure characterised at a June 2026 digital rights workshop as breaching the ICCPR and the African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights, at the same meeting that criticised the cybercrime law's limits on expression.

Individuals have little practical purchase on data held about them. There is no citizen-facing portal through which a person can view or manage their identity data, the pre-enrolment site handling applications only, and identity and nationality disputes reach the ordinary courts under general jurisdiction rather than any mechanism dedicated to the identity system or biometric data. Meanwhile the state is expanding collection: a decree of 17 December 2025 authorised borrowing of more than FCFA 39 billion to finance an urban video-surveillance system.

Sectoral cover is thin. Consumer protection has not yet been adapted to mobile money: the committee established under CEMAC regulation to mediate financial disputes still had to extend tools built for banks and microfinance institutions to electronic money issuers (2023). In health, most practitioners surveyed in 2025 were unaware of any data-governance guidelines applying to their work.

Regional collaboration

Cameroon's most consequential cross-border digital relationship is with Chad, whose only entry point for submarine-cable capacity runs through Cameroon, and it is stalled. The two governments signed a digital cooperation agreement in May 2025 committing to complete the Nana-Mbéré fibre section within fourteen days; the link was still unbuilt in February 2026, by which point the operators' memorandum meant to deliver it had been suspended by Chad's regulator on digital-sovereignty grounds.

Payments are only beginning to reach continental rails. In June 2026 Cameroon was reachable on the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System only for inbound payments, through partners rather than as a direct participant, and the regional central bank's accession to that system in July 2026 brings all six CEMAC states into it, with their financial institutions to be integrated by the end of 2026. Identity travels less far: the 2025 card is recognised within the CEMAC free-movement zone, but no formal agreement provides for cross-border electronic authentication against it.

Where data goes is now a live regional question. An expert panel at the Central African telecoms regulators' conference, attended by Cameroon's regulator, recommended in February 2026 a harmonised framework requiring non-geostationary satellite operators to keep citizens' data on the African continent — a recommendation rather than national law, with no transposition reported. Technical alignment is at an earlier stage, with the national ICT agency urging the country's operators to accelerate the move from IPv4 to IPv6 (June 2026), and the AI roadmap proposing a Central African AI network and an export label for Cameroonian AI products, with no partner states named.

The state operator and Gabon's digital-infrastructure holding signed a memorandum on a terrestrial interconnection of Cameroon, Gabon and Congo over the Central African Backbone (October 2026), with route and cost unstated.

The wider integration position has weakened: Regional Integration scored 37.4 out of 100 in 2023, 36th of 54 and down 1.6 points over the decade, in a country whose only regional economic community membership is ECCAS.

Standards

Enforcement of service standards produced the period's largest penalty: in July 2025 the telecoms regulator fined Orange and MTN a combined CFA 2.6 billion, about US$4.6 million at the time, for poor quality of service and regulatory breaches found in 2024 inspections. The regulator has since gained its own measurement capability, receiving quality-of-service monitoring platforms in January 2026 under the World Bank-funded PATNUC programme, and inspecting network quality and coverage in the field in Douala in April 2026. Separately, the regulator urged consumers, importers and distributors in November 2025 to use only certified terminal equipment.

Inside government the picture reverses. There is no interoperability framework setting the rules for data exchange between state systems, and no data quality framework for government information systems, no monitoring of their uptime, and no guidance for replacing legacy systems (2025).

None of the seven core administrative systems assessed across the state — financial management, the treasury single account, tax, customs, human resources, payroll and e-procurement — has governance arrangements on record covering compliance, security and audit trails over its operations (2025).

Standards do bind where an external party sets them. Cameroon has a unified budget classification and chart of accounts covering both central and sub-national government, and publishes procurement data in line with the Open Contracting Data Standard. The identity card is built to ICAO Doc 9303 in TD1 format with a machine-readable zone and biometric chip, and the regional payment switch renewed independent PCI DSS v4.0.1 certification in March 2026. Where compliance depends on domestic actors it lags: DNSSEC validation across the national internet stood at 56.60 percent in December 2025, and the government's own study found most of the country's data centres small to medium in size and short of certification. The national standards agency is a full ISO member body, participating in 4 technical committees and observing 41 (October 2026), and its catalogue adopted ISO/IEC 27001, 27002 and 38500 as Cameroonian standards in 2014.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Cameroon scores zero out of 100 on Freedom of Association & Assembly, the lowest of all its Ibrahim Index indicator scores and down 12.5 points over 2014-2023 (2023). Media Freedom fell 7.6 points to 40.4, and Freedom of Expression & Belief fell 13.4 points to the same score, and Deliberative & Participatory Governance stands at 22.1 out of 100, 49th of 54.

Digitally, there is nothing to participate through. Cameroon has no national platform on which citizens or businesses can take part in policy decisions, submit petitions or give anonymous feedback. It does operate platforms for complaints, suggestions and information requests about service delivery, but does not demonstrate acting on that feedback and publishes no service standards such as response times or procedures (2025). Nor is there a right-to-information law in force for anyone wanting the records to argue with, though accessibility and disclosure of public records have both improved from a low base over 2014-2023.

Of the four public service portals assessed in Cameroon, only the social insurance and pension portal involves citizens in the design of its services; the tax portal, the job portal and the central service portal do not (2025).

Debate happens anyway, and mostly outside state channels. The 51st plenary of the National Episcopal Conference voiced concern in June 2026 at the growing use of artificial intelligence and its effects on society, putting the Catholic Church into the AI argument; lawmakers including opposition members of parliament criticised the cost and procedural complications of the new identity card in June 2025; and the case for making AI accessible beyond experts and wealthy countries has been argued in the press (June 2025). The national internet governance forum met at Yaoundé on 18-20 August 2026 on moving from fragmented platforms to interoperability, with no resolution or follow-up published. AI itself entered the October 2025 presidential campaign, with synthetic content in circulation.

Finance

Financial sustainability

The 2026 finance law puts FCFA 19.5 billion into the telecoms ministry's programme for a secure and inclusive digital ecosystem, against FCFA 10.3 billion and FCFA 1.0 billion in 2025 for the development and security programmes it merges. The 2026 estimates do not print the source of financing against their digital lines (FY2026): the programme table gives each programme's commitment and payment credits with no split between the Treasury and external lenders.

What the state has put in law is a set of levies. The 2026 finance law caps the levies assigned to the telecoms regulator ART at FCFA 18.5 billion and to the ICT agency ANTIC at FCFA 8 billion, with anything collected above the caps going to the Treasury, up from FCFA 15 billion and FCFA 5.5 billion in 2024. The electronic-security special fund, fed by levies on providers and numbering fees, is held at FCFA 1.5 billion (2026), the same as in 2024.

Two service platforms are carried by private partners against revenue rather than the budget. Impact Palmarès, an Ivorian firm, supplies the foreign ministry's biometric visa system and builds, operates and maintains its Digital Transformation Centre under a public-private partnership running to at least 2032; the contract was amended in November 2025, by when 411,439 paid visas had brought in FCFA 46.8 billion (September 2025). At Douala, INNOVENDI finances a 4G/5G network and smart-port systems upfront and pays the port authority an entry fee and fixed and variable fees tied to port activity (November 2025).

MoUs and other agreements

Cameroon's most consequential digital agreement is with another state telecoms operator: CAMTEL's master service agreement with Ethio Telecom, signed in December 2025, includes guidance on the architecture and deployment of a sovereign government cloud, alongside a strategic alliance to build out CAMTEL's Blue Money payments product. These are framework instruments rather than contracts, and that pattern holds across the rest.

Vendors reach the state directly at municipal level: Douala City Council signed a memorandum of understanding with Huawei on 28 April 2026 to digitise the city's land files and create a digital certificate of possession, an intention rather than a delivered system. In payments, Visa and Afriland First Bank are partnering to expand card issuance and acceptance (March 2026), putting a US card network alongside the domestic and regional rails.

Regionally, a digital cooperation agreement with Chad in May 2025 committed both governments to completing the cross-border Nana-Mbéré fibre section, and ST Digital, the Douala data-centre operator, signed a memorandum with Gabon's national IT agency ANINF on 9 July 2025 to support Gabon's digital transformation. Beyond what is signed, Yaoundé pressed in Seoul in June 2026 for a deeper technology partnership with South Korea — a request made at a diplomatic meeting, not an instrument.

New investments

Cameroon's national intelligent urban video-surveillance system has drawn four successive foreign credits totalling XAF 150.8 billion over eight years, the latest a decree of 17 December 2025 authorising XAF 39.2 billion (about US$66 million) from China Citic Bank. The series began with a US$41.78 million commercial loan from Bank of China, ratified by decree in June 2018, which paid for a police contract with Huawei covering 1,500 cameras in the regional capitals and border towns. A XAF 32.8 billion tranche was authorised through Banco Santander's Hong Kong operation in March 2024, and a third of the same size contracted from China Citic Bank that December.

Some 29 distinct commitments from fifteen financiers are on the record between 2007 and 2026, worth roughly US$2.1 billion, mixing signed loans, approved facilities and pipeline money. Chinese lenders account for over half of that 2007-2026 total, with China Eximbank the largest single financier at around US$869 million across five commitments, ahead of the World Bank at about US$417 million across five. Connectivity takes the biggest sectoral share of that 2007-2026 record, 59% across nine of those commitments, with the video-surveillance tranches next. Almost none is grant money: grants come to a few tens of millions of dollars across the whole record.

The largest single commitment is China Eximbank's US$337.1 million (XAF 199 billion) buyer's credit of December 2015 for the National Broadband Network's Phase 2, on-lent to CAMTEL for a Huawei contract adding 3,000 km of fibre across 13 cities; fully disbursed by the end of 2020, with XAF 180.3 billion outstanding. Of live money, the World Bank's PATNUC project, cut from US$100 million to about US$83 million in a 2025 restructuring and due to close in 2027, is spending — cybersecurity systems worth over XAF 735 million reached the national CIRT at ANTIC on 20 January 2026 — and CAMTEL raised a XAF 44.884 billion (about US$75 million) syndication with Commercial Bank-Cameroun on 21 January 2026 for mobile network expansion. Korea's KOICA put US$12.5 million into the upgraded COLEPS procurement platform (June 2025), the African Development Bank's US$29 million facility through CCA-Bank part-funds telecom equipment imports (December 2025), and a China Eximbank loan for Phase IV of the fibre backbone was authorised by decree in March 2026.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Cameroon went back to Beijing for its backbone in March 2026, authorising a China Exim Bank loan of about 108 billion FCFA by decree of 6 March to finance Phase IV of the national fibre-optic network, which could add some 4,000 km to a Camtel backbone put at over 15,000 km (July 2026). The state operator that owns that network barely exists in retail: Camtel holds 2.67% of the mobile market against Orange's 50.08% and MTN's 47.2% (March 2026).

About 75% of the population lives under a 3G or better signal (2023) and 41.9% of people used the internet (2023). Camtel operated around 180,000 fibre ports and offered 4G in more than 160 municipalities (September 2025). On the Ibrahim Index, Internet & Computers rose 12.9 points over 2014-2023 to 33.4 out of 100, the country's largest infrastructure gain and still 27th of 54, while over the same decade rated public satisfaction with infrastructure fell 22.0 points to 19.3.

The regulator fined Orange and MTN in July 2025 over quality of service and regulatory breaches and inspected networks in Douala in April 2026. Access is simultaneously being narrowed by administrative means: handsets on which customs duty has not been paid were to be deactivated on the networks from 1 September 2026, after a first date of 25 May 2026 was put back, and access was restricted around the October 2025 election. Domestic traffic can exchange at CAMIX, which has points of presence in Douala and Yaoundé. Cameroon is also landlocked Chad's only submarine-cable entry point, though the N'Djamena–Nana-Mbéré link between the two was still unbuilt in February 2026. The state operator and the secondary education ministry signed a framework agreement on 7 October 2026 to interconnect 130 schools in the three northern regions.

Data Storage

Cameroon's sovereign-hosting ambition rests on a physical base its own government review found wanting: CENADI's three-year, 269-page study of the country's data centres, presented in May 2025, found most existing facilities small to medium in size and short of certification, and recommended action on certification, security, connectivity and energy efficiency. A December 2025 industry workshop at Camtel's data centre heard that storing data offshore exposes it to foreign legislation.

The state's answer is Camtel's Zamengoe facility near Yaoundé, presented as the national asset on which government data and digital sovereignty rest (June 2026) and offered to government agencies and businesses as a compliant host in December 2025. Alongside it, the Douala operator ST Digital runs a Tier-3 facility with a sovereign cloud, which the Minister of Posts and Telecommunications, visiting in July 2025, called a potential strategic partner; it operates in Gabon, Congo and Côte d'Ivoire as well and aims to keep African data hosted on the continent (May 2026). A further data centre is under construction in Douala to hold electricity metering data, and the national identity database has run from the police directorate's own data centre since 1994. The social insurance fund runs twin active-active data centres, a primary at Yaoundé and a recovery site at Douala, migrated by the end of 2019 on its supplier's account, and Orange's Douala facility claims 340 racks in two white rooms and 99.82% availability on its own page (October 2026).

What is missing is the layer above the buildings. Cameroon has no shared government cloud platform available to all government entities (2025), and no national government cloud strategy has been adopted. Camtel's December 2025 master service agreement with Ethio Telecom includes a sovereign government cloud workstream, and in July 2026 the same operator opened talks with Amazon Web Services on cloud, satellite and AI cooperation — the sovereign build and the hyperscaler conversation running at once.

Energy

Power failure is the ordinary condition of doing business in Cameroon: 93.3% of firms surveyed had experienced outages, averaging 10.4 in a typical month (2024). That is the first-order constraint on the digital estate — unreliable energy supply and limited bandwidth are among the problems facing the country's data centres, on the government study presented in May 2025.

Reach has improved slowly and unevenly. National electricity access reached 72% of the population in 2023, up from 71% the year before, but the gap inside that figure is about 70 percentage points: 95.8% of the urban population had access against roughly 26% of the rural population (2023). Cameroon's Access to Energy score rose 8.3 points over 2014-2023 to 46.7 out of 100, 22nd of 54 African states. Generation is unusually clean by regional standards: renewables accounted for 73.2% of electricity generated in 2024, up from around 60-65% in 2020-2022. Tariffs were harmonised from November 2024 at 50 XAF per kWh for the first 110 kWh a month, rising in bands to 99 XAF above 400 kWh.

Distributed supply is being opened up rather than left to the utility: in December 2025 the regulator granted the first private-sector solar mini-grid authorisation, to REI Cameroon for the Voundou pilot. The 2040 AI roadmap plans solar-powered edge computing nodes to distribute processing capacity. The grid is meanwhile becoming a data system in its own right: 20,000 smart meters began rolling out in May 2026 under the electricity-sector recovery programme, with a Douala data centre being built to hold what they collect. Sector transparency lags the build: energy is the weakest of Cameroon's environmental data categories on the Open Data Inventory (2024).

Technical Capacity

The government's own diagnosis puts dependence on foreign technology alongside missing specialised skills: the Minister of Posts and Telecommunications named both among the challenges facing artificial intelligence development in July 2026. The state's flagship system demonstrates the point — the national identity card system is run for the police directorate under a fifteen-year build-operate-transfer contract with a German firm — and the identity programme as a whole is financed from external and private sources rather than the domestic budget, with its coordinating committee going inactive when donor funding lapsed.

The disciplines that let a state run systems it did not build are largely absent. Cameroon has no data quality framework for government information systems, no system for monitoring their uptime and no guidance for replacing legacy systems (2025). A government entity focused on GovTech exists, but no coordination body leads digital initiatives and no entity monitors what government spends on them, and there is no strategy, unit or private-sector collaboration on public sector innovation.

Where capability is being added, it is being added at the agencies rather than across the administration. The national ICT agency ANTIC is pressing operators to move the country's networks from IPv4 to IPv6 alongside its DNS security programme (June 2026), and has extended digital transformation support to a majority of the country's councils (July 2026). The telecoms regulator received quality-of-service monitoring platforms in January 2026 under the World Bank-funded digital transformation programme, giving it its own measurement capability rather than the operators'. Outside the state there is a working developer community, visible through local meetups and Cameroon-based open-source groups, small against the scale of what the country proposes to build.

Cybersecurity

ANTIC recorded 17,500 cybercrime complaints in 2025, with declared financial losses of FCFA 5.8 billion, and between January and late September 2026 counted 21,280 compromised machines, 39 attacks on public-administration websites and 5,369 vulnerabilities across 150 public and private websites it scanned. It processed 32,500 legal requisitions in 2025, about 30% more than the year before. The same agency operates the national

Computer Incident Response Team and the national public key infrastructure, so incident response and the certificate authority underpinning trust in government digital services sit inside one body. That team took delivery of roughly FCFA 735 million of intrusion detection and prevention hardware and software on 20 January 2026, funded by the World Bank through the PATNUC digital transformation programme, and ANTIC also ran a cyber-risk workshop for fintech operators in November 2025.

ANTIC signed the `.cm` domain with DNSSEC on 8 April 2025 and presented it as an act of digital sovereignty, but adoption below the zone is thin: national DNSSEC validation stood at 56.60% in December 2025, leaving nearly half of national DNS traffic unvalidated. The agency's target of 98% validation and full RPKI adoption by mid-2026 was restated in June 2026 as full DNSSEC coverage by the end of the year. On the identity side, the system carries encrypted storage, AFIS deduplication and ICAO-compliant digital signature verification, and a January 2025 duplicate-identity clean-up included an inter-ministerial security review.

The largest sustained security spending is not defensive. The national intelligent urban video-surveillance system has drawn four successive foreign credits over eight years, the most recent authorised by presidential decree in December 2025. Mandatory security audits of state systems under a 2012 decree are being moved onto a telecoms-ministry platform whose second phase went to consultants in July 2024, with no launch on record. The framework governing all of it remains Law 2010/012 of 2010 on cybersecurity and cybercrime, which civil society organisations argue contains provisions that limit freedom of expression.

DPI

Data Exchange

Cameroon has no government interoperability framework setting the rules for data exchange between state systems (2025), and what exchange exists has been built bilaterally, system by system. The business registration platform exchanges data automatically with the Directorate General of Taxation, with integration to the social security fund CNPS and the trade register RCCM planned but not built (2024). Between the national identity system and the rest of government there is no digital link at all: birth certificates presented for a card are checked by eye, and the inter-ministerial Infocentre meant to harmonise the registers was not operational (2024). The social registry is not joined to the identity or civil registration systems (2025), and the social insurance and pension system exchanges data with nothing else in government (2025).

Most of the core administrative systems the GovTech Maturity Index assesses in Cameroon are nonetheless recorded as exchanging data with other systems — over interfaces built with no framework governing any of them (2025).

The intent has since been stated: the posts minister told the national internet governance forum in August 2026 that systems built in isolation must be made to communicate through common standards, shared registers and secure exchange, and the state operator was mandated to carry national interoperability, with no design or timetable published. One cross-border exchange is live: the preferential certificate of origin for exports to China is applied for online and transmitted to Chinese customs (October 2026).

The legal basis is validated and not enacted. An e-government bill received technical validation at a workshop in November 2025 and was ready for ministerial finalisation in January 2026; it would make public information accessible by default and place interoperability under GovTech Cameroun. The national AI strategy of July 2025 calls for a government data lake and national interoperability standards. Underneath both, the state has no data quality

framework for its information systems, no monitoring of their uptime and no guidance for replacing legacy systems (2025). Health is the sector with a real integration effort: DHIS2 carries routine health data and openIMIS, adopted in 2023, was built to HL7 FHIR and linked to the CamerHealth beneficiary registry (2024).

Digital Identity and CRVS

Cameroon's new identity card system went live in February 2025 under a foreign contractor: the police force that issues it, the DGSN, runs it under a fifteen-year build-operate-transfer contract signed with the German firm Augentic in May 2024. Issuance began on 3 March 2025. The card carries ten fingerprints and is deduplicated one-to-many; it meets ICAO Doc 9303 in TD1 format and is recognised across the CEMAC free-movement zone, though no agreement provides for cross-border electronic authentication. Financing is primarily external and private rather than budgetary.

The card is compulsory from age 18 and closed to anyone younger. Décret n°2025/059 requires online pre-enrolment before a physical appointment, sets issuance within 48 hours of validation and fixes validity at ten years; the same decree lets an application be suspended where nationality is doubted or where it is a first application made after age 30, routing late applicants into discretion rather than the 48-hour path. The IDCAM portal charges 10,000 FCFA, about US$16 (February 2025), a cost opposition lawmakers criticised as higher than under the old system (June 2025). Around 82.8% of adults held a card, leaving some 2.5 million without (2024).

The card is required to open a bank account, to register a SIM — capped at twelve per identity — and to draw Filets Sociaux transfers and CNPS pensions (2024), and to register and vote. There is no portal on which a person can see or correct the data held about them; idcam.cm takes applications only, and no standalone regulation of digital identity exists. A civil registration law enacted in December 2024 created a unique personal identification number and gave digital civil-status certificates the same legal standing as paper, though that number is not yet joined to the adult identity system. Digital civil registration is still a donor pilot, a UNDP-BUNEC partnership having issued more than 50,000 digital civil-status documents across 26 Far North centres since 2020 (2025).

Three foreign vendors run the identity document stack between them: a German firm for the national identity card, a Luxembourg firm for civil registration, and an Ivorian group for consular documents and secure printing (2026).

Digital Payments and Fintech

Cameroon's central bank, BEAC, joined the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System in July 2026, carrying all six CEMAC states in with it — but the country appears in the PAPSS network only through its Extended Network, for inbound transactions, rather than as a full participant (2026). GIMACPAY processed 20.3 million transactions worth FCFA 863 billion in 2025, 40% more by number than in 2024, across 153 participants; BEAC owns 99.2% of its operator and settles through the SYGMA real-time gross settlement platform, and the scheme supports person-to-person transfers, merchant and business payments, cross-border transfers, salaries and government payments (2023). Cameroon had 30.9 million registered mobile money accounts, more than its adult population, and the largest such market in Central Africa (2024), while 59.6% of adults made or received a digital payment and merchant-payment use roughly doubled from a low base between 2021 and 2024, and 60.87% of adults held an account (2024).

Government is moving its own money onto the rails slowly. Decree No. 2022/8001 supplies the legal basis for electronic payment of taxes, customs duties and other state revenue, and a prime ministerial order of May 2025 made the Treasury's Tresor Pay platform compulsory for several departments collecting non-tax revenue. The first digital payments to people came through a COVID-era emergency cash transfer paid into mobile money accounts, which beneficiaries preferred to receive that way (2021). New entrants keep arriving: Flutterwave holds a BEAC

payments licence through a partnership with Ecobank (June 2025), state operator CAMTEL has tied its Blue Money service to an alliance with Ethio Telecom (December 2025), and Visa is expanding card issuance with Afriland First Bank (March 2026).

Oversight is thinner than the plumbing. The 2011 framework consumer law reaches financial, banking and communications services and requires written disclosure of the cost of consumer credit, but consumer protection has not been adapted to mobile money: the national economic and financial committee that mediates financial disputes still had to extend tools built for banks to electronic money issuers (2023). GIMAC renewed its PCI DSS certification in March 2026; BEAC's accounts are independently audited and published (2026), and its regional payment services report puts Cameroon at 65.10% of CEMAC payment transactions by number and 56.95% by value (2024). Refugee documents are legally good for a mobile money account under BEAC's electronic money rules, yet providers unfamiliar with them refuse registration, so access turns on case-by-case advocacy. A Cameroonian fintech and a logistics group presented to Douala traders a pilot that pays Chinese suppliers in yuan from CFA francs and consolidates and tracks the cargo (2026).

Registries

Cameroon's registers are digital and nearly empty. The latest national business census counted only 62,902 formal, properly structured businesses, 14.6% of the business stock, while 97.4% of about 3.7 million informal production units are absent from the trade register (2024). EasyBusiness.cm is a nationwide single window with the OHADA trade and personal property credit register digitised, and more than 25,000 businesses had registered through the UNCTAD-built online registration platform by December 2020. The tax register is likewise digital and nationwide, with online taxpayer identification since 2020, and grew from 80,000 to 400,000 registered taxpayers between 2014 and 2024, even as personal income tax contributes about 1% of GDP (2024). It is also tied to the identity system for individuals, who register with their national identity card number, while companies are keyed on their RCCM number (2025).

Land is the weakest. An estimated 85% of land is unregistered (2020); there is no nationwide digital cadastre, only a multipurpose pilot at Soa that had field-identified 20,000 parcels across 330 square kilometres by March 2026 and titling otherwise manual. A World Bank-financed project called in June 2026 for firms to build a land information system for Yaounde and Douala and scan 510,000 land files. Since 1 July 2025 a non-objection letter from the traditional chief has been required before direct registration or concession of 20 hectares or more can proceed, a customary gate on a state register. Standardised addresses are only now being built, through a national postal addressing plan laid by the postal operator Campost with a start-up, FindMe (June 2025).

Birth registration completeness was last measured at 61.9% (2018), and digital certificates reach ten municipalities (January 2026). The state's largest attempt to close the gap has fallen short: a drive launched in 2024 under a World Bank-funded education reform programme to reach one million primary-school pupils holding no certificate was found far from its target in an August 2026 assessment, and the Basic Education minister ordered regional officials on 26 August 2026 to submit pupils' files to the competent courts before 15 September, restarting special mobile court hearings from September; no count of certificates issued under the 2024 drive is published, and the court route is not discretionary — the civil-registration law requires a declaratory judgment wherever the 90-day statutory deadline was missed. The registers can also certify people who do not exist: a 2024 pension-fraud case turned on more than 13,000 fake birth certificates. The electoral register has been biometric since 2012–13 and is continuously revised, and ELECAM is deduplicating roughly 8.2 million entries (2025). The Unified Social Registry began registration in August 2024 through 100 pilot social centres across the ten regions but was not yet nationwide (2026), and many intended beneficiaries lack the identity card needed to open a payment account (2022).

Sectoral management information systems

Declared dependent children on Cameroon's state payroll rose 55.3% in 21 months, from 594,728 in June 2024 to 923,307 in March 2026, after a February 2024 decree raised the monthly child allowance from FCFA 2,800 to FCFA 4,500. The biometric payroll-verification system running since early 2025 has flagged tens of thousands of public servants drawing undue benefits (June 2026). Figures given by the public-service minister put more than 342,049 promotion and tenure acts processed automatically on that platform since January 2025, with secure electronic signature in 37 of 40 administrations (October 2026). A human resources system runs across the public service with a self-service portal and exchanges data with other systems, payroll is linked to it, and HR records carry the national identity number (2025) — which social insurance and pension records do not, that system exchanging data with no other part of government.

On the money side, an integrated financial management system supports transaction processing and budget preparation but reaches central government only, and the treasury single account it supports is only partly used (2025). Revenue administration is being rebuilt: alongside a customs management system that exchanges data with other government systems and the tax directorate's TAS, GovIn, ATOM and FUSION suite, the finance ministry awarded a €7.15 million contract, about CFA 4.7 billion, in April 2026 to build SIGIT, a KfW-financed integrated tax and duty management system designed to interoperate with customs, budget and treasury systems.

Sectoral systems mostly collect statistics. In health, 45% of health workers surveyed reported interoperability problems with the national DHIS2 system (2025), against a strategy target of electronic medical records in 70% of facilities that rural services have not met. Education runs the same way: education data collection depends heavily on paper rather than digital means (2023), and a new integrated sectoral platform for education management information was launched in May 2025. In justice, 42 of 60 targeted court registries are connected to the RJ-Secure network while the Criminal Procedure Code has police reports and statement registers signed sheet by sheet, a statement going on any sheet of paper where there is no register (2005). The employment fund's jobseeker database and SYSTAC for driving licences stand alone, and no farmer registry reaches a government exchange. The family health directorate's bulletin read completeness of monthly activity reports at 96% and timeliness at 89% for October to December 2025 (2026). A press account citing the ministry said the electronic medical record had been tried in about fifty facilities, with no date set for national deployment (2023).

A German cooperation project description of June 2020 records the national police's digital case and warrant system as barely used and makes use of a national digital crime database a priority.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Cameroon has no national online public service portal or one-stop shop through which citizens and businesses can transact with the state, and no government job portal either (2025). What exists is sectoral. The tax directorate runs impots.cm and otp.dgi.cm for filing and payment, routed through Tresor Pay and accepting MTN Mobile Money, Orange Money, Campost, bank transfer and Visa (2026); a social insurance and pension portal is in use for both registration and benefits, and citizens are involved in designing its services. The clearest success is at the border: the biometric e-visa has been fully operational since 30 April 2023, covering application, payment and biometric enrolment, and has issued more than 540,000 visas in three years (May 2026). CAMCIS handles customs declarations, including the import duty assessed on every mobile device brought into the country (March 2026), and PROXIGAB launched in January 2026 for small enterprises and young entrepreneurs.

Procurement is the furthest ahead. The COLEPS platform was upgraded with a US$12.5 million KOICA grant (June 2025), adding online contract signing, real-time monitoring and bank integration for bid securities, and procurement data is published to the Open Contracting Data Standard — the one substantial thing government does publish. On the platform 1,173 contracts were awarded in 2025 from 2,334 published notices, on the minister's report to the National Assembly (November 2025).

None of it is run as one government. There is an established state entity focused on GovTech, but no steering committee or council leading GovTech initiatives, and nothing monitoring digital spending across government (2025), and the GovTech and digital transformation strategy remains in draft rather than adopted. PATNuC, the World Bank-financed transformation programme launched in August 2023, has not established a data exchange layer. Local government is being brought in separately, through an update of the Digital Master Plan for the 394 decentralised local authorities, announced in July 2025, and ANTIC support reaching 230 councils (July 2026). Measured readiness is low — 0.45 on the UN E-Government Development Index, 141st (2022) — and Effective Administration scores 40.7 out of 100, 39th of 54 (2023). Citizens can lodge complaints and information requests on government platforms, but the state neither demonstrates acting on that feedback nor publishes any service standards such as response times (2025).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The diagnostic behind Cameroon's local-government digitisation drive is that 68.5% of local authorities have no structured computer network and 57.8% have no digitally trained staff (June 2026). That baseline was presented with DIGI-COR, a CFA 92 billion local-government digitisation programme for which the government was seeking financing (June 2026), and it follows an update of the Digital Master Plan for local government announced in July 2025, which covers the 394 decentralised authorities.

Support has reached most councils on paper without changing much on the ground. The national ICT agency ANTIC counts 230 councils reached with digital transformation support, about 64% of the total (July 2026), yet in the North West only 48.6% of councils have a functional website (July 2026) — a shortfall ANTIC has publicly told them to close.

The national systems mostly stop above the council. Cameroon's integrated financial management information system is scoped to central government (2025), even though the budget classification and chart of accounts are unified across both tiers (2025), so the plumbing for consolidating local spending exists while the system that would carry it does not. Digital government more broadly runs at national level (2023), with infrastructure concentrated in Douala and Yaoundé.

The registers councils depend on are being digitised piecemeal and locally. There is no nationwide digital cadastre (2026), only a multipurpose pilot in Soa commune and a memorandum to pilot digitised land procedures in Lékié division; Douala City Council signed its own memorandum with Huawei to digitise its land files (April 2026); and direct land registration or concession of 20 hectares or more now requires a non-objection letter from the traditional chief before it can proceed (July 2025). On civil status, councils have begun issuing digital birth certificates, which the 2024 law gives the same legal worth as paper ones (January 2026), starting from Limbe I, on a UNDP-implemented, Denmark-funded system covering councils in the Far North, North West and South West (January 2026). A municipal app built under an urban development project, Mboa City, through which residents report local problems, was handed to the local-government fund for national rollout (October 2026).

Rural digital data capture

Cameroon's rural counter is still a paper counter: civil and criminal records are still managed on paper (2025), in a country whose gendarmerie counts 444 brigades and 160 posts (2025).

What digital capture does exist outside the cities is donor-built and geographically bounded. UNDP and the civil registration office BUNEC have equipped civil status centres in the Far North with computers, biometric kits, printers and dedicated software (2025). In health, the national digital health plan plans to expand electronic medical records and found most health staff, especially in rural areas, without computer skills (2020).

The substrate for capturing anything is thin. The rural connectivity component of PATNuC targets 328 unserved localities by 2028, under a tender opened in October 2025. Rural electricity access (2023) and rural internet use (2022) both run far below the urban levels.

The rural economy the data would describe scores comparatively well. Cameroon's Rural Economy sub-category stood at 63.8 out of 100 in 2023, 24th of 54 countries and up 1.6 points — its second best-scoring sub-category of sixteen. Within it, rural land and water access improved substantially over the decade to 2023 while rural market access moved sharply the other way.

Technology

AI

Two years of national consultation have produced a 2040 AI roadmap and no AI anywhere in the state's citizen-facing services. The roadmap, built on seven strategic pillars and running to 2040, was presented in Yaoundé in July 2025 alongside a national strategy from the Ministry of Posts and Telecommunications whose data and digital infrastructure pillar calls for a government data lake, mass digitisation of public services and national interoperability standards. A year on the strategy had not been finished: at the cabinet meeting of 30 July 2026 the Prime Minister instructed that it be completed. Meanwhile no chatbot or AI-enabled discussion forum is used in any of Cameroon's citizen engagement channels (2025).

The chain behind the strategy is well documented and slow. Cameroon has been working towards a national strategy since the National Consultations on Artificial Intelligence of 25-26 June 2024; the drafting mandate went on public tender in March 2025 to Cabinet Danielle Moukouri, a Cameroonian digital-law firm; a second edition of the consultations opened in Yaoundé on 7 July 2025 under Minister Minette Libom Li Likeng, framed by its organisers as a sovereign platform for organising the country's AI sector. The government plans to work with ST Digital on rolling out the strategy (July 2025), and an AI-governance workshop for public administrations was held with the International Telecommunication Union in February 2026 to feed recommendations into implementation. The roadmap itself proposes new governance institutions and a sovereign large language model trained to work in the country's local languages — proposals, not bodies or systems that exist.

What is actually running is private. Rail operator Camrail has made artificial intelligence the core of its safety and performance strategy, with an obstacle-detection camera in service on its trains and the DIBIE customer portal and Digitrack driver-monitoring tool still to go live (November 2025). The public argument about the technology has started ahead of the policy: the 51st plenary of the National Episcopal Conference voiced concern at the growing use of artificial intelligence and its effects on society (June 2026), putting the Catholic Church into the debate. On the International Telecommunication Union's latest African ranking Cameroon scored 46.3 out of 100, 30th of 42 countries and below the continental average of 56 (July 2025).

ICT Industry

The state buys its largest digital systems abroad rather than from the sector at home: the national identity credential runs on a fifteen-year build-operate-transfer contract with a German supplier (February 2025), and the rest of the identity document stack is contracted out the same way.

The domestic side of the sector is small but not absent, and its most prominent firm is courted for the national AI programme. ST Digital, founded in Cameroon, operates in four countries with three certified data centres and aims to keep African data hosted on the continent (May 2026), and the government plans to work with it on rolling out the national artificial intelligence strategy (July 2025). Incumbents are being contested from below and from outside at once: local fintechs are competing with established banks for the international trade finance market (October 2025), while Flutterwave holds a BEAC payments licence covering Cameroon through a partnership with Ecobank (June 2025), giving a foreign fintech regulated access to the CEMAC payments market.

The market these firms sit in is concentrated and the rules around it have been getting worse, not better. Mobile is split between Orange and MTN, with the state operator's retail presence negligible (March 2026), even as the telecoms sector grew strongly through 2024. Cameroon's Business and Competition Regulations score fell 6.2 points over 2014-2023 to 48.7 out of 100, 35th of 54 African countries, within a business and labour environment sub-category that also fell. The state does not buy from its own sector by design either: there is no procurement policy prioritising bids from startups or small and medium firms (2025). Its regulatory reach over the operators is limited — a first date of 25 May 2026 for blocking handsets on which customs duty is unpaid was put back after operators objected that no test phase had preceded it, and a finance ministry communiqué of 20 August 2026 set 1 September 2026 in its place.

Innovation ecosystem

The machinery for founding and growing technology firms in Cameroon is privately built and privately funded. The government has no strategy or programme to improve public sector innovation, no government entity focused on it such as an innovation lab, and no collaboration with the private sector on it, and it provides no financing to startups or small firms for innovation and has no policy to support govtech startups (2025). What exists instead is a hub network: at least ten Cameroonian hubs are members of AfriLabs, with focus areas spanning fintech, agritech, the internet of things and women's entrepreneurship, and ActivSpaces operating sites in Douala, Buea and Bangangté (2026).

The money behind them is thin. Startup funding rose sharply in 2024 but stayed far below the level associated with an established startup base, over a tracked base of fewer than a hundred companies. External capital does some of the work the state does not: the French seed fund Digital Africa is investing in the Cameroonian payments fintech Futa (February 2025). Cameroon ranked 123rd of 133 economies in WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2024, in the bottom quartile.

Products are nonetheless reaching the market from the hubs themselves. KMR Start-up HUB launched Pyramid in June 2026, a Cameroonian suite of browser, e-mail and streaming services whose data is held on infrastructure inside the country, and a mobile-money treasury product for small and medium enterprises, Momo Helep, is on the market (June 2026), taking mobile money from consumer transfers into business cash management. The state's own contribution is a single platform, PROXIGAB, launched in January 2026 to support SMEs and young entrepreneurs, beside a tax regime in which approved innovative start-ups pay no tax for five years, then 15% company tax with a 30% research credit (2023). The posts ministry has recommended a Startup Act (June 2026); no bill is on the repository. The barrier new entrants actually hit is the payments layer: a Cameroonian games developer has publicly argued that the payment aggregation monopoly threatens the country's digital economy after its definition of online games swept in video-game studios (February 2025).

Capacity

Literacy

Nearly half of Cameroonians who had never been online gave not knowing how to use the internet as their main reason, in the national ICT household survey that found 34.0% of people aged 10 and over had used it in the previous three months (2022), 48.2% in urban areas against 14.7% in rural ones. The barrier the survey picked out is skill rather than reach, and it sits on top of a school system whose measured performance has been going the wrong way.

Cameroon's education score on the Ibrahim Index stood at 48.0 out of 100 in 2023, 35th of 54 African countries and 6.5 points below where it was a decade earlier, with enrolment at 41.3 and quality at 47.2 both down over the period and completion, at 55.6, up. The same profile scores human resources in education — trained and qualified teaching staff — lower still, at 38.6 and 36th of 54 (2023), and falling across the decade. In the schools themselves, very few public primary schools have computers, and ICT where it is taught is overwhelmingly theoretical for want of equipment (2024).

The state does offer digital skills programmes free to citizens and schools (2025). Around that, the education system's own records are still aggregated centrally from paper returns sent up by schools, the digitisation aimed at pupils directly is a student digital identity planned with a mobile operator (June 2026), and financial literacy has a platform of its own for comparing bank charges (June 2025).

Training and skills

Cameroon's draft artificial intelligence strategy sets a target of 60,000 trained AI specialists by 2040, 40 per cent of them women (July 2025) — a number with no counterpart in what the state currently runs. For its own workforce, the World Bank's 2025 index records a government strategy for basic digital skills in the public service that has not reached full implementation.

What officials actually receive comes as discrete events tied to particular systems: two sessions on the road-fund management platform, in Garoua in April 2025 and in Douala in July 2025, a cyber-risk workshop ANTIC ran for fintech operators in November 2025, and an AI-governance workshop with the International Telecommunication Union in February 2026. The gap that leaves is visible in local government, where the diagnostic behind the digitisation programme found a majority of councils with no digitally trained staff (June 2026).

The pipeline into that workforce runs through a handful of universities with dedicated computer science and ICT departments and an active local developer community, neither of which the state meets on the way out: it operates no job portal, so public-sector vacancies are not advertised or applied for through a platform of its own (2025).

Research institutions

The institutions that would let Cameroon produce knowledge in computing rather than only consume it are still proposals. A National High-Performance Computing Centre, a sovereign scientific database on a dedicated national platform and a centre for digitising scientific and technical information are among the ten priority areas for artificial intelligence in scientific research set out at cabinet while the national strategy was still in drafting (July 2026), alongside centres of excellence for AI in the roadmap behind it.

What exists is teaching capacity: several universities run dedicated computer science and ICT departments (2021), among them the National Higher Polytechnic Institute at the University of Bamenda, the National Advanced School of Engineering at the University of Yaounde I with its EU-accredited MSc in computer science engineering, UCAC-

ICAM, and the Catholic university institutes at Bamenda and Buea. The network connecting higher education was built on external finance, under a Chinese government concessional loan for an E-National Higher Education Network project with the Ministry of Higher Education.

Inclusion

Access to services

Cameroon scores 34.9 out of 100 on the Ibrahim Index's Equal Access to Public Services measure (2023), 32nd of 54 and essentially flat over the decade, while Equal Socioeconomic Opportunity fell 4.1 points to 26.1, 44th of 54.

Most routes to a service run through the national identity card, legally required to open a bank account, register a SIM and receive social protection benefits including Filets Sociaux cash transfers and CNPS pensions (2024). Adult coverage is incomplete and lack of a document is a barrier unbanked Cameroonians cite, the card is not free, and rated ease of obtaining an identity document sits among the country's worst-scoring and most deteriorated indicators (2023). Those with no birth record have a fallback: an attestation d'état civil issued after hearings before the administrative and traditional authority and two family witnesses. Downstream, people without identity cards cannot open the payment accounts social protection pays into (2022), and the programme has reached only a minority of poor households (2025).

Non-nationals' legal route does not reliably work. Refugees and asylum seekers hold UNHCR-recognised documents that are legally accepted for SIM registration and, under BEAC's electronic money regulation, for mobile money accounts, but some providers are unfamiliar with them and refuse registration, so access depends on case-by-case UNHCR advocacy (2019). Civil registration likewise bars neither refugees nor internally displaced people and is backed by targeted programmes, but completion stays low where the registration infrastructure is weak, in the Far North, North-West and South-West (2024).

Cost and language gate the digital routes: a basic mobile data bundle costs more than the UN Broadband Commission's 2%-of-income affordability threshold (2023), and some government websites are published in both English and French (2023). The offline route survives by default rather than design — even the digitised civil status centres in the Far North lack trained staff, reliable internet and equipment (2025). For persons with disabilities there is no law or policy governing ICT accessibility, only general disability laws (June 2025). Newer gates sit in front of the old ones: direct land registration or concession of 20 hectares or more has required a non-objection letter from the traditional chief since 1 July 2025.

Digital divides

Geography is where the divide is actually measured. The 2022 national ICT household survey put rural internet use far below the urban rate, with not knowing how to use the internet the barrier non-users cited most often. Electricity runs along the same line, rural access standing at a fraction of urban access in 2023. A rural connectivity component of the World Bank-backed PATNuC project targets 328 unserved localities by 2028. The state's own machinery shows the same shape: the local-government digitisation programme's baseline finds most councils without structured computer networks and many without digitally trained staff (June 2026), and ANTIC has publicly urged North West councils to close a shortfall in functional websites (July 2026). The telecommunications minister counts the digital and regional divide among the challenges facing artificial intelligence (July 2026), and reporting on the 2040 targets flags limited connectivity, data-centre capacity and the rural-urban access gap as unresolved (July 2025).

The gender line is measured regionally: women in Sub-Saharan Africa were 26% less likely than men to use mobile internet (2025). Policy has begun to address it — Germany funds a programme to 2026 addressing the position that women, particularly in rural areas, benefit too little from digitalisation, and the AI roadmap sets a target share of women among the specialists it intends to train by 2040.

Exclusion is also written into procedure. The identity decree routes late first-time applicants, and those whose nationality is doubted, into a discretionary suspension process rather than the standard one, and pre-enrolment must be completed online through the IDCAM portal, for a fee. Biometrics carry their own failure mode: the opposition accused the electoral body of striking thousands of voters from the register in a December 2024 clean-up over rejected fingerprints, taken on enrolment kits some of which date from 2012. Against that, the government offers freely available digital skills programmes to citizens and schools (2025).

None of the citizen-facing government platforms assessed in the 2025 GovTech Maturity Index offers universally accessible omnichannel access, and the feedback platforms carry no support for users with disabilities such as voice commands.

Data

National statistics

Cameroon's statistical system is better at publishing than at collecting: across the World Bank's five Statistical Performance Indicator pillars, the sources of data are the weakest and the data products the strongest, with data use, services and infrastructure all in the middle band (2023).

The shortfall in sources is literal. No agricultural census has been run in twenty years, against a business census inside the decade, and no labour force survey in the past ten years, against two household surveys, one agricultural survey and three or more health and business surveys. The most recent population census falls inside twenty years but outside ten, so the state plans on population figures more than a decade old (2023).

The institutional frame is newer than the data it governs. Law No. 2020/010 establishes a National Statistical Information System coordinated by the National Institute of Statistics, running cross-sectoral databases drawn from administrative records held across government under the National Strategy for the Development of Statistics 2021-2030. Capacity is rising from a low base: the Ibrahim Index puts the capacity of the statistical system at 39.7 out of 100 in 2023, 36th of 54 African states, up 4.8 points over the decade.

Administrative data is not yet a substitute for survey data. The education ministries' management information systems aggregate centrally from paper school returns (2024), and birth registration completeness has not been re-measured by a nationally representative survey since 2018. Where administrative counts carry money, they have proved unreliable: declared dependent children on the state payroll rose sharply after the child allowance was raised, and the Finance Ministry's verification census is finding forged and duplicate birth certificates behind it (2026).

Self-monitoring is partial: the financial management information system captures expenditure linked to the Sustainable Development Goals only in part, and non-financial performance indicators for only a selection of programmes (2025). Sector statistics are strongest where a regulator produces them — the telecoms regulator's 2024 market observatory puts sector revenue at CFA 1,022 billion, 3.16% of GDP, on 18% growth.

Open data

There is no open data portal publishing government datasets for reuse in Cameroon (2025), and no policy or institution behind one: no government body owns data governance and no data governance strategy exists. The right to ask for what is not published is equally unsettled — no right-to-information law is in force, with a draft in consultation and nothing published on requests received or granted, and a draft e-government law discussed at a PATNUC workshop in November 2025 would create a general right of access to public information but had not been enacted by the end of that year. The records regime is improving from a very low base: the Ibrahim Index scores accessibility of public records at 29.9 out of 100 in 2023, 26th of 54, up 11.8 points over the decade, and disclosure of public records at 32.9, 29th.

Cameroon meets none of the sixteen transparency tests the GovTech Maturity Index applies (2025): nothing is published on cloud usage, interoperability compliance, public investment projects, digital skills results, digital transformation progress, data governance, data protection complaints, regulator or online service performance, right-to-information implementation, public sector innovation, startup support, government responses to citizens, or public service standards.

What does reach the public is uneven by domain rather than absent. On Open Data Watch's inventory (2024), balance of payments and government finance statistics score 7.5 out of 10 while international trade scores 4.5 and money and banking 5; food security and health facility data score 7, against 5 for gender statistics and education outcomes and 4.5 for reproductive health; and among environmental categories energy is the weakest at 4.5, against 7 for natural resources and 6.5 for pollution. The strongest single case is procurement: the e-procurement portal is in use and its data is published to the Open Contracting Data Standard (2025), the one domain where publication follows an international schema. Openness is otherwise promised rather than delivered — the 2040 AI roadmap commits the government to adopting an open data policy and building a state data lake (July 2025), neither of which is in operation.

Use of satellite data

No national space or geospatial data policy had been adopted, and no national Earth observation programme was in operation, as at August 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

CAMTEL opened talks with Amazon Web Services in July 2026, with the US Embassy present, on cloud, satellite and AI cooperation, seven months after an agreement with Ethio Telecom that covers a sovereign government cloud. In payments, Visa and Afriland First Bank agreed in March 2026 to expand card issuance and acceptance, setting a US card network alongside the mobile money, Blue Money, GIMACPAY and PAPSS rails that carry domestic and regional payments.

China activities

Cameroon's national intelligent urban video-surveillance system has drawn four successive foreign credits totalling XAF 150.8 billion over eight years, the most recent authorised in December 2025, and Chinese banks financed it from the start. Phase I rested on a US$41.78 million commercial loan from Bank of China, ratified by decree on 5 June 2018, which funded a DGSN contract with Huawei for 1,500 cameras across the ten regional capitals and seven border and coastal towns, 2,000 portable two-way radios and command centres, with the national centre

inaugurated in Yaoundé in August 2019. A second Bank of China loan of US$41.6 million followed on 15 May 2019 for Phase 2, 76.1% disbursed by the end of 2020, though as at February 2022 no implementation of Phase 2 had been identified. A third credit of XAF 32.8 billion from China Citic Bank was contracted on 2 December 2024.

The fibre backbone is the larger commitment. China Eximbank signed a US$337.1 million preferential buyer's credit with MINEPAT on 8 December 2015 for Phase 2 of the National Broadband Network — 20-year maturity, five-year grace, 2% interest — on-lent to CAMTEL to pay a US$396.6 million Huawei contract adding 3,000 km of fibre across 13 cities; it was fully disbursed by the end of 2020, with XAF 180.3 billion outstanding. Cameroon returned to the same lender by decree in March 2026 for Phase IV of that backbone. Government systems have gone the same way: a CNY 216 million concessional loan under a framework agreement of 22 September 2017 paid for a US$33 million contract with Anhui YISHANG Digital Science for trade facilitation and electronic certificate verification, and ZTE agreed a grant in December 2015 to build turnkey data centres in Yaoundé and Douala for the National Emergency Telecommunications Network. In April 2026 Douala City Council signed a memorandum of understanding with Huawei to digitise its land files and issue a digital certificate of possession.

Chinese lenders account for the majority of Cameroon's recorded digital-sector finance, and China Eximbank alone is its largest single financier.

EU activities

Cameroon's identity card system runs on a European contract: the DGSN signed a 15-year build-operate-transfer contract with the German firm Augentic in May 2024. The same pattern reaches revenue collection: in April 2026 the Ministry of Finance awarded a €7.15 million contract, about CFA 4.7 billion, to an ARABSOFT, ORADIST, C2D and DBS consortium to build SIGIT, an integrated tax and duty management system financed by the German development bank KfW on a 24-month timeline and designed to interconnect with customs, budget and treasury systems.

German development money also runs to smaller programmes: BMZ is funding a EUR 3 million programme from 2023 to 2026 to close the digital gender divide, which addresses women in rural areas benefiting too little from digitalisation, and funded a EUR 3 million project from 2015 to 2019, now closed, advising spatial-planning decision-makers on harmonised soil and groundwater data for the South West and North regions. A second loan of XAF 32.8 billion for Phase II of the urban video-surveillance project was authorised in March 2024 through Banco Santander in Hong Kong, after China Construction Bank Corporation withdrew from the financing in 2021. The French seed fund Digital Africa said in February 2025 that it would invest in the Cameroonian payments fintech Futa.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf state, sovereign fund or Gulf-owned company held a financing, infrastructure or operator position in Cameroon's digital sector as at August 2026.

India activities

India's one valued instrument in Cameroon is nineteen years old. The Pan-African e-Network country accord was signed on 3 September 2007 by the Minister of External Relations, against a commitment from the Government of India of FCFA 1,400,000,000 covering network implementation, recurring costs and five years' maintenance. Nothing reports what it delivered or whether it still runs. The relationship is live at ministerial level without being live on the ground: India's Commerce and Industry Minister named digital technologies among areas for expanded cooperation when he met the Prime Minister at WTO MC14 in Yaounde on 26 March 2026, which is an expression of interest and not an instrument.

Digital sovereignty

Cameroon's 2024 data-protection law makes every transfer of personal data abroad subject to prior authorisation by the Personal Data Protection Authority, which must first confirm that a legal instrument with the destination country is in force, and fines an unauthorised transfer FCFA 10 million to 50 million. Beyond personal data, the World Bank's 2025 GovTech index records no government cloud policy, and state data reaches the state operator's Zamengoe centre agreement by agreement: the baccalaureate board's examination data are to be held there under a January 2026 agreement with Camtel, in a national cloud Camtel describes as wholly Cameroonian.

The consular system has an exit written into it: Impact Palmarès builds, operates and maintains the foreign ministry's Digital Transformation Centre, which is to hold all consular data, for the life of its contract before handing it to the government. Whether the state holds the source code and operating skills for the identity card system Augentic runs under its build-operate-transfer contract, or can exit that contract early, was not on record as at September 2026.

The terms on which Camtel's master service agreement with Ethio Telecom, which covers a sovereign government cloud, governs data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026. Camtel's talks with Amazon Web Services had settled neither where data would be stored nor the division of responsibilities between the two companies (July 2026).

Regionally, an expert panel at the Central African telecoms regulators' assembly recommended in February 2026 that satellite operators keep citizens' data on the African continent and establish terrestrial gateways within the region.

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